

aska



DAVID SHAW
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CHEF FREDRIK BERSELIUS

Originally from Stockholm, Sweden, chef Fredrik Berselius has spent most of his culinary career in New York City, bringing his love for nature to his urban surroundings through food. Berselius opened Aska – Swedish for ‘ashes’ – in its first rendition in 2012, garnering acclaim for bridging the culinary heritage of his upbringing with the immediate environs of his Brooklyn address.

Within a year, Aska earned Berselius his first Michelin star, and Bon Appetit named Aska one of the ten best new restaurants in America.

In the summer of 2016, Aska reopened in a new, bilevel space – with a main dining room, garden, and cellar bar – located in a restored 1860s

warehouse building near the edge of the Williamsburg Bridge. Within a few months, Aska earned Berselius his second Michelin star, being one of only ten restaurants in the city to hold the honor. Shortly thereafter, Aska received a three star New York Times review by Pete Wells.

With an emphasis on ingredients from the surrounding Northeastern U.S. region and influenced by Berselius’ Scandinavian homeland,

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Upon arrival, I was ushered to one of the best tables in the restaurant, which has a perfect view of the open kitchen as well as the garden behind. The table was covered by a black tablecloth and got a spotlight overhead, which is a perfect scenery for photo shooting. To start, I ordered a glass of apple juice that was infused with verbena.

BLADDERWRACK	Blue mussel emulsion	RYE	Grilled rye flatbread started with the yeast of young wild pine, cultured butter with black locust flowers and dill oil
KOHLRABI	Kohlrabi compressed with linden leaf oil and linden flower vinegar	HAKE	Poached hake, salad of cabbages and seaweed, beach plums and bronze fennel
POTATO PANCAKE	Pommes soufflé, vendace roe smoked in dried carrot tops and elderflower	QUAIL	Roasted quail from Vermont, with summer truffle and burnt pine
RAZOR CLAM	Seasoned with preserved black pine and cucumber reduction	CURRENT	Tart filled with preserved black currant, red gooseberry and fresh cheese
CAVIAR	Imperial Oscietra caviar, peas, preserved mushrooms and green gooseberry, broth made from the outer shell of the pea	HAY	Ice cream made from toasted hay with summer flowers and a sauce made from fermented honey and bedstraw cordial
LANGOUSTINE	Charcoal grilled tail, brain, and claw salad with chamomile	MIGNARDISES	Cep and spruce fudge White Chocolate Chewy Beet Crispy Lichen and Gold
ONION	Grilled onion and scallop with a broth made from roasted onion and black currant leaf		

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BLADDERWRACK

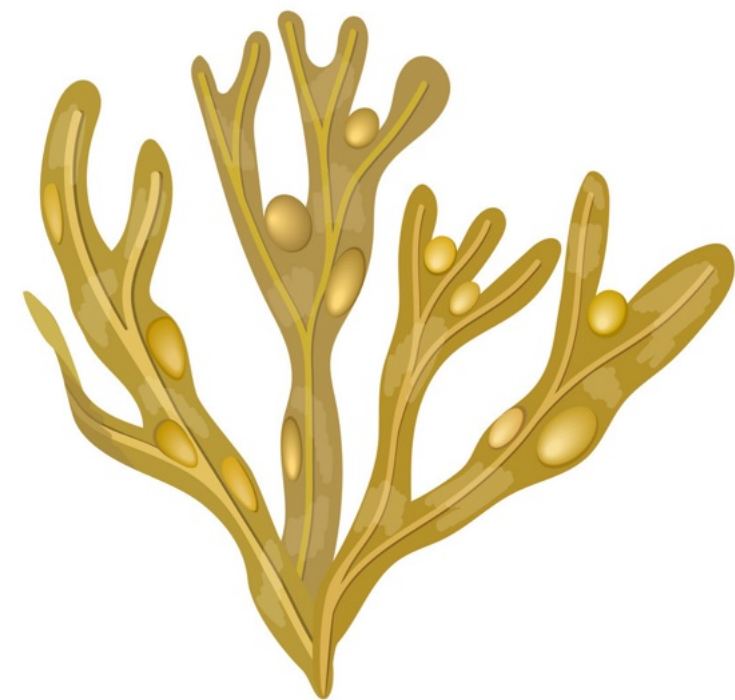
Blue mussel emulsion

Aska is where you can relax and truly enjoy the gourmet food. There's no dress code and no certain rules here, the food and the environment were ultimately soulful and elegant but fun as well. The service at Aska was very impressive, usually, two chefs would come together to present a dish, and one of them would explain the details and answer your questions. They would also chat with you, and as a solo diner, I didn't feel awkward at all, even chef Fredrik himself would come to greet me and talk about his culinary ideas.



Aska changed my mind of contemporary cuisine. Oftentimes contemporary cuisine can be dangerous, new ingredients and new cooking methods, if not been used properly, can easily destroy the balance of a dish. Aska is not the case, every dish here at Aska was perfectly balanced. If I say that dining at a French cuisine restaurant is like listening to a Mozart Symphony, then a journey at Aska is like experiencing the harmony of nature: the whisper of leaves, the singing of birds, and the sound of waterfalls and rivers.

Aska is very good at using natural and unusual ingredients, like the pine, lichen, and some rare flowers and herbs, which are hardly ever seen in other dining places. The first course was already a surprise for me. A dish consisted of crispy bladderwrack and blue mussel emulsion, very oceanic but with a similar flavor of sobacha. Within one bite, you could almost imagine a scene that the Vikings were sitting along the seashore and cooking on the open campfire.



BLADDERWRACK



KOHLRABI

Linden leaf oil and linden flower vinegar

The order of dishes is very important, especially for a tasting menu. If a chef decides to jump one dish to another which has a totally different flavor, he is either a bad chef or an extremely confident and wise chef, Fredrik is the latter one. The dishes at Aska always have different tastes, but the sudden switches were all very impressive and successful, what you feel is not underwhelming but true surprises. Within two small bites, I already traveled from the seashore to an elegant orchard. Here in the picture was a Kohlrabi dish with linden leaf oil and linden flower vinegar. Kohlrabi belongs to the cabbage family, but is rather more similar to the taste of daikon or turnip. As a raw dish, I was afraid it would burn my palate, like many other salad dishes. But in terms of both aroma and taste, what I got was pure freshness and rich floral scents, and the texture of kohlrabi was extremely silky.



POTATO PANCAKE

Pommes Soufflé, Vendace Roe and Elderflower

I was just at a sunny summer orchard and then I was at a peasant's home. This potato pancake was a true autumn dish, within the crispy skin was the extraordinarily creamy, silky, and delicate filling, almost like a flowing egg custard. Everything was within one bite.



RAZOR CLAM

Black Pine and Cucumber Reduction

I would have to compare this razor clam dish to Momofuku Ko's. The one at Momofuku Ko had too much pineapple flavor and the result was that the dish was over sweet and sour. This Aska's razor clam dish was also an unusual interpretation, but the use of black pine and cucumber was much better, though the pine was raw, it was edible and brought essential natural grassy aroma. The razor clam itself was also outstanding, it was seared so it dehydrated, but the result was that the flavor (umami) concentrated, so even the razor clam itself was very tasty.



CAVIAR

Peas, Mushroom, Green Gooseberry

Aska is almost perfect and I nearly liked every dish, If I have to name one dish that didn't surprise me enough, I would say this caviar dish. I've tried a lot of stunning caviar dish so this one seems to be a little bit ordinary. The caviar was from Poland as I was told, the accompaniments were peas and mushroom, and the dish was served cold, the feeling was a little bit too chilling, the flavor and creaminess and richness of caviar didn't show off at all in this dish.



LANGOUSTINE

Brain, Tail, Claw with Chamomile

The next course was a trilogy of langoustine. First up was an unusual Langoustine brain dish with a broth made from the body of the langoustine and garnished with pickled spicebush flowers. Then I moved on to the tail of langoustine, which was also the main body, simply charcoal grilled, then brushed with chamomile oil and topped with pansy flowers. The final one was almost like a palate cleanser — a claw salad with rutabaga “pedals” that was lightly pickled with sea buckthorn and chamomile. I was surprised by the langoustine brain, almost like the bone marrow but much less greasy. The tail was very juicy and with beautiful smoky and floral scents.





ONION

Grilled Onion, Scallop, Black Currant Leaf, Caper

Though this dish was stated as an onion dish, the scallop was still the main role in this course. The scallop was almost like a carpaccio, and it was combined with the grilled onion and a stock made from roasted onion and black currant leaf. I've seen such combination or similar interpretation at Maaemo, and the flavor was totally what I expected, but the surprise part was the caper, caper added a little bit of sweetness and sourness to the dish, it actually reminded me of the famous scallop dish by Jean George which evolves with a sauce made from caper and raisin. Here the onion provided certain sweetness so I kind of detected the similarity, though they were prepared in totally different ways.



RYE

Grilled Rye Flatbread
Cultured Butter with Black Locust Flowers, Dill Oil

The Aska team took a brief summer break and it was the second day when they restarted their late-summer service. One of the major changes in the menu was this bread course, which was currently a rye flatbread started with the yeast of young wild pine, paired with cultured butter with black locust flowers and dill oil.

The flatbread was well moisturized and I could easily detect the freshness of pine, a lot of dishes at Aska evolved with pine so, at this point, it was already not a surprise but rather a homey feeling. The black locust flower added essential sourness and sweetness to the butter which let it become unusual, but I personally prefer the dill oil which had a very nice green color as well as an extremely rich dill scent.



BLACK LOCUST FLOWER



HAKE

Salad of Cabbages and Seaweed, Beach Plums and Bronze Fennel

Nordic or Scandinavian cuisine is very refreshing and oftentimes you won't see a dish that is deeply cooked, the hake here was just slightly poached, and the inner part was translucent. A creamy sauce was showering the fish, which was an emulsion made with chicken eggs, reduced hake broth, bladderwrack oil, and crème fraîche. The emulsion actually was a surprise to me because in Nordic cuisine, a light clear jus is more common, similar to French's consommé rather than a thicker creamier bisque. To balance the greasy taste of hake, a salad part was added, which was a combination of seaweed, beach plums, bronze fennels, as well as leaves of nasturtium.



QUAIL

Summer Truffle, Burnt Pine

When I was booking Aska, I felt like I liked to, or needed to eat more seafood at Aska, and thus I ordered the Pescetarian menu. But there's only one dish at Aska that I can never miss, that is the quail, one of the most famous dishes at Aska. The quail dish also had two parts, one was the breast with shaved summer truffle, and the other part was the quail leg surrounded by dried lichen. I extremely like the sauce served with the quail, which was a sauce made with preserved lingonberry and burnt pine butter, sweet, sour, and creamy, it tasted almost like a perfumed Chinese soy sauce reduction.



The breast of quail was actually very different from the duck's. Though both are poultry, quail has a much firmer and juicier breast, and the skin was much less oily, much thinner, and crispier.

In my favorite duck dish in Chinese cuisine, a whole duck is been braised till very tender, then a cup of soy sauce, together with sugar, water, and salt is added, the dish is ready when the soy sauce

becomes thicker and the color should be a beautiful ruby. This quail dish actually reminded me of my favorite duck dish back in China, because the sauce was similar to the soy sauce reduction. It was quite shocking for me when I took my first bite.

The leg was much tenderer and juicier than the breast, and you could also enjoy the pure crispy skin part at the lower leg part, which was quite interesting. The garnish, which was the lichen and the pine, was more than a simple garnish, the lichen became part of the petit fours later.



CURRENT TART

Black Currant, Red Gooseberry and Fresh Cheese

Before my dessert course, a pre-dessert was served. It was a currant tart with black currant, red gooseberry, and fresh cheese. The crust is very crumbly and sandy in terms of texture, I believe it was a *pâte sablée*. Both currant and gooseberry had very strong and deep fruity notes, unlike other berries or grapes, they were more oriental and sophisticated.



FENNEL SPARKLING

My main dessert course was quite interesting, a hay flavored ice cream with a sauce made from fermented honey and bedstraw cordial. Such a dessert dish reminded me of the one I had at Momofuku Ko, which was a wild rice ice cream. The flavors were similar, both woody and rustic, but Aska's hay ice cream was smoother and it was not just ice cream, it was paired with a very sophisticated sauce, with a freshness from the bedstraw cordial, and a subtle sweetness from the honey.



HAY

Ice cream made from toasted hay with summer flowers and a sauce made from fermented honey and bedstraw cordial



Æbleskiver

With a filling made from meadowsweet

To pair with the ice cream, a Danish “brioche” was set as a side dish. The term for this danish snack is Æbleskiver, such setting was quite similar to Per Se's famous “Coffee and Donuts” which was a dish evolving brioche and coffee-flavored semifreddo. However, I believe that Per Se did a better job because the æbleskiver here was a little bit too dry.



MIGNARDISES

Cep and spruce fudge | White Chocolate | Chewy Beet | Crispy Lichen and Gold

The final petit fours, or mignardises, were abnormal as well, no wonder why many people don't understand Aska's tasting menu and found the dishes here quite confusing. Only the white chocolate was common, none of the others were gettable at other restaurants. The chewy beets tasted like dried orange peel, or apricot. Cep is an edible mushroom, spruce is similar to pine, and the fudge made from these two ingredients tasted very unforgettable, it was savory. The crispy lichen, as I mentioned before, was from the quail dish, and the fried lichen was very impressive, moreover, it was topped with edible gold.